A Cautious Approach

Paul had all the leverage he could want — and he didn’t use the hammer.

Where this study fits

The Epistle to Philemon · three studies · this study highlighted

01 Philemon 1–7

A Cautious Approach

Greetings · Grace and Peace · Gratitude · Gladness

02 Philemon 8–19

A Comprehensive Appeal

Necessity · Responsibility · Liability

03 Philemon 20–25

A Compelling Appendix

A Personal Word · A Public Word · A Parting Word

Study 1 sets the stage: before the request, Paul greets, blesses, thanks, and rejoices over Philemon.

The situation behind the letter

Commentary · Introduction

1

A runaway

Onesimus, a thieving, runaway slave, flees to Rome

Stole from Philemon

2

Meets Paul

Through Paul he meets the Lord

3

Sent back

With Tychicus, carrying Colossians, to Colossae

He could be killed

4

The request

“Receive him … as a brother in Christ”

vv. 8–19

Questions it raises: Why send him back? Is the Bible in favor of slavery? Why not tell Philemon to free him?

A cautious approach, verse by verse

Philemon 1–7 · the commentary's outline

vv.1–2	**I. Greetings — where they were from; whom they were for**	*δέσμιος · συνεργός*
v.3	**II. Grace and Peace — the Father; the Lord Jesus Christ**	*χάρις · εἰρήνη*
v.4	**III.A Gratitude — when Paul prayed**	*μνεία*
vv.5–6	**III.B–C Why and what Paul prayed — love, faith, sharing**	*κοινωνία · ἐπίγνωσις*
v.7	**IV. Gladness — joy, consolation, hearts refreshed**	*σπλάγχνα · ἀναπαύω*

How Paul claims and commends them

Philemon 1–2 · Commentary I.B

Philemon
the saint

- “Our beloved friend and fellow laborer”
- A friend of Paul
- Hosts the church in his house

Apphia
the sister

- Probably Philemon’s wife
- Special to Paul, to Philemon, and to the church
- Gets the house ready for the church

Archippus
the soldier

- “Our fellow soldier”
- A Christian soldier, not a Roman one
- Served in the same army as Paul

“Our” (ἡμῶν) — Paul and Timothy claim them as their very own. There is nothing like expressed appreciation.

Grace and peace — a greeting with a point

Philemon 3 · Commentary II

Grace

χάρις

- Favor in spite of demerit (Rom. 5:8)
- Lord — power: His deity (Eph. 3:20)
- Jesus — person: one of us, one with us
- Christ — position: His works prove Messiahship (Matt. 11:2–6)

Peace

εἰρήνη

- Peace with God — positional, every believer has it (Rom. 5:1)
- Peace of God — guards (garrisons) heart and mind (Phil. 4:6–7)
- Comes from laying our burdens on Jesus

The burdens bag: take your burdens to the Lord — and leave them there.

Gratitude and gladness

Philemon 4–7 · Commentary III–IV

When he prayed
v. 4

- “Always in my prayers”
- Prison gave time for what mattered

Why he prayed
v. 5

- Love toward all the saints — Onesimus is one now
- Faith toward the Lord Jesus — love grows from faith

What he prayed
v. 6

- Effective sharing of faith
- By knowing every good thing we have in Christ

Why he was glad
v. 7

- Great joy and consolation
- Hearts (σπλάγχνα) refreshed — “by you, brother”

“If we don’t have it, we can’t share it” — like a bald barber selling hair restorer.

Discuss and apply

Philemon 1–7 · from the study's questions and applications

Discuss

1. Paul could command Philemon. Why does he begin with greetings, grace, gratitude, and gladness instead?
2. What burden have you taken to the Lord and then picked back up?
3. Is there a believer you have quietly left out of "all the saints"?

Apply

Say It Out Loud

Tell one fellow worker, "You are a blessing to me."

Leave the Bag at the Front

Pray one worry through with thanksgiving — and leave it.

Love All the Saints

Pray by name for one believer you find hard to love.

In one line: The great Christian tact — the velvet glove, not the iron fist.